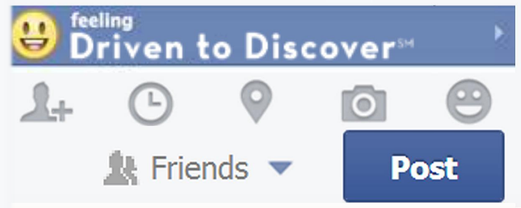
Research Centers Struggling to Communicate: SOCIAL MEDIA as a New Pathway

with Dave Sukharan, McNair Scholar, Sara Axtell, Ph.D., Jeffrey Corn, M.P.P., & Jonathan Miller, B.A.



The Center for Urban and Regional Affairs (CURA) is a university research center that was created in 1968.
By applying non-profit and business marketing theories, CURA's online engagement with stakeholders has spiked.

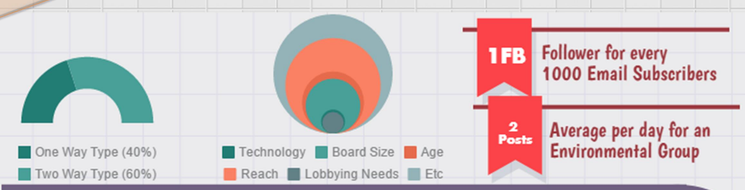


Much research never reaches the practical stage: Knowledge Gap.
e.g., 50% of Healthcare Research

Traditional media is shrinking. Social media is growing.
Facebook= 2nd Most visited Site

Research Centers can use Social Media to disseminate findings.
But How?

1 METHODS



1 FB Follower for every 1000 Email Subscribers

2 Posts Average per day for an Environmental Group

Grunig (2011)
researched and tested communication styles by one to two way intent.

Nah and Saxton (2012)
classified non-profits by 9 criteria.

M&R 2015 Benchmarks
provided a friendly, detailed radar of non-profit efforts



Categorized CURA activities
to create a campaign plan for a wholistic view.

Decided on a UNITED identity for CURA
Many activities. Many themes. Too many.

Identify our Audience
Discussions about CURA's needs pointed towards the General Public.



Measured Impact
Used Facebook Insights tool to track Engagement over time.

Created Comparisons
Compared CURA Facebook following with other university research institutes.

SEE Takeaways

TRIO Ronald E. McNair Post-Baccalaureate Achievement Program
University of Minnesota
Center for Urban and Regional Affairs (CURA)
University of Minnesota

2 Top Tips and Takeaways

Make it a tradition in your organization.

Research shows numerous benefits of social media, but it takes a group commitment.

77% of public relations specialists value social media as a vital tool.
Less than 20% nonprofits are using it fully.

Many managers do not value social media



Knowledge Management Publicity Relationship Building

Become an informative news source.

News searching is the 2nd most practiced online activity

The Internet has outstripped TV as a news source. Most individuals trust/use social media as their main news source.

Social media is the 1st



Use multimedia posts. Use narrative. Connect.

Most posts are JUST links or text; multimedia posts stand out among small organizations. Tagging other orgs and creating a network exponentially boosts views.

Storytelling/Narrative style posts facilitates participation and understanding- especially in non-experts. This is extremely important for university research centers.

WARNINGS

Offer a balanced news report.

Create an accurate image of your organization.

Don't seek dialog right away.

3

Urban Agriculture
- Growing communities

United Identity

Affordable Housing
- Empowering residents

Ethnic Populations
- Fusing culture and community

BEFORE



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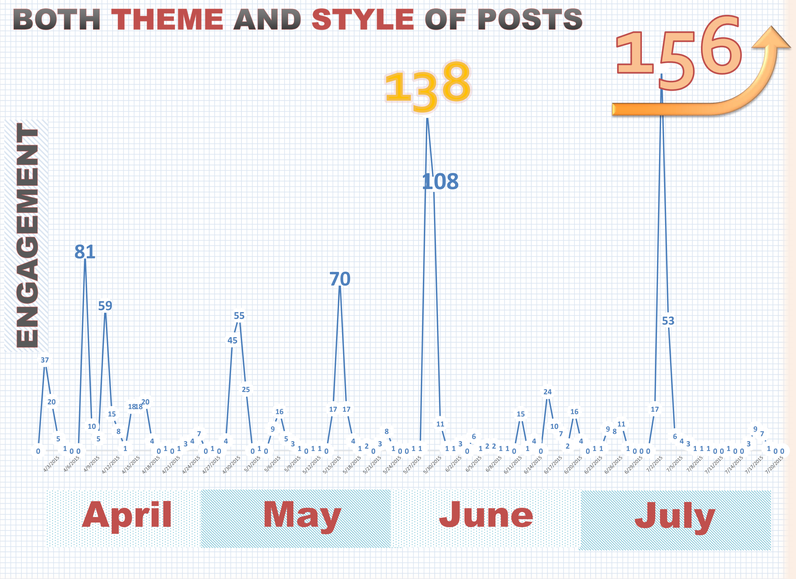
What could a filmmaker, Minnesota's American Indian community and the social services sector have in common? The common thread is Lann Briel and the valuable, CURA-funded, community-based research she is doing with the American Indian Family Center (AIFC). Whether you're a student, community member or nonprofit partner, read on. #CURAStudents #RelevantResearch #UMNProud #CURAthingoftheweek

AFTER

1.3K	10X	223
People Reached	Above Average	Post Clicks

4

UNDERSTAND: USERS ENGAGED BY BOTH THEME AND STYLE OF POSTS



5

Further Studies

Does FB engagement translate to real-world discussion?

Does this apply to larger organizations?

How do you extend theories to all Web 2.0? (email, newsletters, Twitter)

Can a standard handbook be created for university research centers?

Limitations

This study was restrained by time. Environmental scans (survey, focus group) was skipped . The study only tells the tale of one organization. A more systematic literature review is necessary.

Selected Reference

Grunig, J. E. (2011). Public relations and strategic management : Institutionalizing organization – public relationships in contemporary society . Central European Journal of Communication, 1(2011), 11-31.

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